



Central Asia

THE FIVE CENTRAL ASIAN NATIONS rise up from hot deserts in the west and south to cold, high mountain ranges in the east. The area has oil, gas, and mineral reserves, as well as other natural resources, but water is often scarce and agriculture is limited. The four northern nations were once part of the Soviet Union and are now independent nations. Afghanistan is a landlocked country and three-quarters of its land is inaccessible terrain. It was invaded by the Soviet Union in 1979, prompting a continuous series of civil wars. The 2001 invasion by American and other Western forces overthrew the fundamentalist Islamic regime and led to democratic presidential elections, but Afghanistan is still unstable. Wrecked by more than 30 years of warfare, it is one of the poorest and most deprived nations on Earth.

One of the world's largest gold mines is at Muruntau in the Kyzyl Kum desert in Uzbekistan.

FESTIVALS IN AFGHANISTAN

Despite the horrors of recent years, the Afghans still celebrate important Islamic festivals, notably Eid ul-Fitr, which marks the end of the holy month of Ramadan. People visit friends and family and eat a festive meal together. The art of storytelling still flourishes in Afghanistan, as does the *attan*, the national dance.



An Afghan man carries bread with which to break the Ramadan fast.

Children in Kabul, Afghanistan, made homeless by war

LIFE EXPECTANCY

As a result of war, drought, and poverty, people in Afghanistan can expect to live an average of only 51 years, one of the lowest life expectancy rates in the world. Infant mortality is extremely high. Health services have almost completely collapsed and few trained doctors and nurses are available to help the sick. Many children have been orphaned or made homeless, and few have been able to go to school.

